RDG-P5 · PRÁCTICA 02

Multiple choice

Hoja 02 · Ensayo de opinión · dificultad 2 de 4

6 preguntas (31–36) · 2 puntos por pregunta · tiempo orientativo: 18 minutos · sin consultar la teoría

You are going to read an article about personal fitness technology. For questions 31–36, choose the answer (**A, B, C** or **D**) which you think fits best according to the text. Mark your answers on the answer sheet.

Counting the wrong things

A columnist considers what we lose when we measure everything

My watch congratulated me last Tuesday. I had, it informed me, 'smashed' my daily target – a verb that would once have struck me as absurd and that now, to my faint embarrassment, produces a small glow of satisfaction. I had also, as it happens, spent much of the evening pacing the length of my kitchen in order to reach the number, an activity that did nothing for my health and a good deal for the watch's statistics. It was at about this point that I began to wonder who was serving whom.

The enthusiasts for self-tracking – and they are many, and often evangelical – would say that I had missed the point. The device, they argue, is simply a mirror: it shows us what we actually do rather than what we imagine we do, and people who see the truth about their habits are more likely to change them. There is something to this. A friend of mine, a GP, tells me that several of her patients have been nudged off the sofa by the modest tyranny of a step counter, and I would not wish to deny them their improved blood pressure. If a gadget on the wrist persuades someone to walk to the shops rather than drive, it has arguably done more good than most public health campaigns.

My quarrel is not with the information but with what happens to it once it becomes a target. Economists have a name for this: Goodhart's law, which holds, in its popular form, that a measure which is turned into a goal soon stops being a good measure. Step counts are a case in point. The figure of ten thousand a day, which many devices still offer as a default, did not emerge from a laboratory; it is generally traced to a pedometer marketed in Japan in the mid-1960s, whose name translates roughly as 'ten-thousand-step meter'. A large study of older women published in 2019 found that the benefits appeared to level off at around seven and a half thousand. The number on my wrist, in other words, owes rather more to a sales department than to science, which would matter less if it had not been quietly transformed from a rough guide into a daily verdict.

Much the same has happened to sleep. Trackers that once offered a rough indication of how long we had been unconscious now award nightly scores, and some people have begun, quite literally, to lose sleep over them. Sleep researchers have even coined a term, orthosomnia, for patients whose pursuit of perfect data has itself become a source of insomnia. It would be hard to imagine a neater illustration of the problem: a tool designed to help us rest has, for a minority of its users, become one more thing to fail at.

Defenders of the technology are quick to point out that nobody is forced to treat the numbers as commandments. That is true, but it is also somewhat disingenuous. The devices are designed, with considerable skill, to be hard to ignore: they buzz, they praise, they send gentle reminders when we have been still for too long, and they reward unbroken 'streaks' in a way that makes missing a single day feel like a small bereavement. To say that users are free to disregard all this is a little like saying that a casino does not oblige anyone to stay until dawn.

What troubles me most, though, is less the anxiety than the narrowing. Whatever can be counted tends to crowd out whatever cannot. A walk becomes a quantity of steps rather than an hour in which one noticed the weather

or thought through a problem; a night's sleep becomes a score rather than a rest. The things that resist measurement – the pleasure of a meal, the quality of a conversation, the sense of having spent a day well – do not disappear, but they come to seem less real than the things that have a number attached.

I have not thrown the watch away. I am not, I suspect, temperamentally suited to grand gestures, and I am still mildly pleased when it tells me I have done well. But I have switched off the reminders and stopped looking at the sleep score, and I try to treat the remaining figures as I would a weather forecast: worth consulting, occasionally useful, and in no position to tell me how my day actually went. It is a modest compromise. It has also, so far, been the most restful thing I have done in years.

31 What does the writer imply about his behaviour last Tuesday?

A It was fairly typical of the way most people use devices of this kind.
B It showed that his fitness had improved considerably.
C It did more for the device's records than for his own well-being.
D It embarrassed him more than the watch's praise had done.

32 What is the writer's attitude to the enthusiasts' argument in the second paragraph?

A He dismisses it as little more than clever marketing.
B He finds it more persuasive than he had expected to.
C He accepts it, but only where patients are concerned.
D He acknowledges that it has some merit.

33 The writer mentions the Japanese pedometer in order to

A suggest that a widely accepted figure has commercial rather than scientific origins.
B show that the health benefits of walking were recognised long before modern research began.
C prove that ten thousand steps a day is too many for most people.
D illustrate how Goodhart's law first came to be formulated.

34 What point does the writer make about sleep trackers in the fourth paragraph?

A They have become less accurate than earlier devices.
B They can create the very problem they are intended to solve.
C Most of the people who use them now sleep badly.
D Sleep researchers have been rather too quick to criticise the devices.

35 What is the writer's view of the claim that nobody is forced to treat the numbers as commandments?

A It is false, because the devices cannot be switched off.
B It is fair, since the reminders are easy to ignore.
C It is accurate but misleading.
D It holds for occasional users but not for enthusiasts.

36 Which best describes the writer's overall attitude to self-tracking devices?

A wholehearted rejection
B reluctant admiration
C amused indifference
D qualified acceptance

Hoja de respuestas

Marca una sola letra por pregunta. Al corregir, 2 puntos por acierto; los errores no restan. Anota también el tiempo empleado: el objetivo en el examen son unos 18 minutos.

Nº	A	B	C	D	Puntos
31	A	B	C	D	/ 2
32	A	B	C	D	/ 2
33	A	B	C	D	/ 2
34	A	B	C	D	/ 2
35	A	B	C	D	/ 2
36	A	B	C	D	/ 2
				Total	**/ 12**

Tiempo empleado: _____ minutos.

SOLUCIONES

2 puntos por acierto. Cada solución indica el pasaje, una respuesta propia como la que pide el método (§2.2), por qué la clave es correcta y por qué falla cada distractor, con su tipo (§7) y la cita del texto que lo descarta. Los números de sección remiten a RDG-P5_Teoria_v1.

Clave rápida

Nº	Clave	Tipo de pregunta	Distractores	Teoría
31	**C**	Implicación	A §7.7/7.3 · B §7.7 · D §7.1/7.5	§3.2 · §4.3
32	**D**	Opinión y actitud	A §7.7 · B §7.7 · C §7.3	§4.1 · §4.3
33	**A**	Propósito	B §7.7/7.1 · C §7.3 · D §7.5	§5.1 · §6.1
34	**B**	Detalle	A §7.1/7.5 · C §7.3 · D §7.4/7.7	§6.2 · §6.1
35	**C**	Opinión y actitud	A §7.3 · B §7.5 · D §7.7	§4.3 · §4.1
36	**D**	Global	A §7.3 · B §7.1/7.8 · C §7.6	§5.4 · §4.4

Explicación por pregunta

31 · C · Implicación

Pregunta: What does the writer imply about his behaviour last Tuesday?

Pasaje: párrafo 1. **Respuesta propia:** Que fue absurdo: dar vueltas por la cocina solo sirvió para mejorar las cifras del reloj.

A It was fairly typical of the way most people use devices of this kind.
Falla (ausente §7.7, alcance §7.3). El autor habla solo de su experiencia (My watch congratulated me last Tuesday); el párrafo no dice nada de otros usuarios.

B It showed that his fitness had improved considerably.
Falla (ausente §7.7). Lo contradice el propio texto: la actividad did nothing for my health. Que el reloj lo felicite no prueba ninguna mejora.

C It did more for the device's records than for his own well-being.
Correcta. El autor dice que la actividad did nothing for my health and a good deal for the watch's statistics, y remata con who was serving whom: quien salió ganando fue el reloj. La opción reformula esa ironía sin repetir sus palabras (§6.1).

D It embarrassed him more than the watch's praise had done.
Falla (eco léxico §7.1, lógica §7.5). Toma to my faint embarrassment, que se refiere a la satisfacción que le produce el elogio, y fabrica una comparación que el texto no hace.

Teoría: §3.2 De dónde sale una inferencia · §4.3 Ironía, understatement y concesión

32 · D · Opinión y actitud

Pregunta: What is the writer's attitude to the enthusiasts' argument in the second paragraph?

Pasaje: párrafo 2. **Respuesta propia:** Les concede parte de razón: los relojes han ayudado a algunas personas.

A He dismisses it as little more than clever marketing.
Falla (ausente §7.7). There is something to this excluye el rechazo, y el texto no habla de publicidad. Decir que el reloj ha hecho more good than most public health campaigns es un elogio, no una acusación.

B He finds it more persuasive than he had expected to.
Falla (ausente §7.7). El texto no dice qué esperaba el autor: There is something to this expresa una concesión, no una sorpresa.

C He accepts it, but only where patients are concerned.
Falla (alcance §7.3). Los pacientes son solo el primer ejemplo. El segundo vale para cualquiera: If a gadget on the wrist persuades someone to walk to the shops rather than drive.

D He acknowledges that it has some merit.
Correcta. Tras exponer el argumento ajeno (they argue), el autor concede: There is something to this. Lo apoya con dos ejemplos, los pacientes de su amiga y quien va andando a la tienda. La concesión es limitada, porque el párrafo siguiente abre su objeción, pero es real: es el patrón de §4.3.

Teoría: §4.1 La voz del autor frente a las voces citadas · §4.3 Ironía, understatement y concesión

33 · A · Propósito

Pregunta: The writer mentions the Japanese pedometer in order to

Pasaje: párrafo 3. **Respuesta propia:** Para mostrar que la cifra de los diez mil pasos sale de un producto comercial, no de la ciencia.

A suggest that a widely accepted figure has commercial rather than scientific origins.
Correcta. El podómetro explica de dónde sale la cifra, que did not emerge from a laboratory, y el autor lo resume al final del párrafo: owes rather more to a sales department than to science.

B show that the health benefits of walking were recognised long before modern research began.
Falla (ausente §7.7, eco léxico §7.1). Toma la fecha (in the mid-1960s) y le da un sentido que el texto no le da: el podómetro era un producto, no un hallazgo sobre los beneficios de caminar.

C prove that ten thousand steps a day is too many for most people.
Falla (alcance §7.3). El estudio citado trata de older women y dice que los beneficios appeared to level off, no que diez mil pasos sean demasiados para la mayoría. Además, prove es mucho más categórico que el texto (§6.4).

D illustrate how Goodhart's law first came to be formulated.
Falla (lógica §7.5). Los diez mil pasos son un ejemplo de la ley (Step counts are a case in point), no el origen de su formulación.

Teoría: §5.1 Para qué sirve un fragmento · §6.1 Grados de paráfrasis

34 · B · Detalle

Pregunta: What point does the writer make about sleep trackers in the fourth paragraph?

Pasaje: párrafo 4. **Respuesta propia:** Que pueden provocar justo lo que debían remediar: el insomnio.

A They have become less accurate than earlier devices.
Falla (eco léxico §7.1, lógica §7.5). La frase once offered a rough indication contrasta lo que daban antes los aparatos con las puntuaciones de ahora; no habla de su precisión.

B They can create the very problem they are intended to solve.
Correcta. La paradoja está en dos frases: los pacientes whose pursuit of perfect data has itself become a source of insomnia y la conclusión, a tool designed to help us rest has, for a minority of its users, become one more thing to fail at. La opción la abstrae (§6.2).

C Most of the people who use them now sleep badly.
Falla (alcance §7.3). El texto habla de some people y de a minority of its users, no de la mayoría.

D Sleep researchers have been rather too quick to criticise the devices.
Falla (voz §7.4, ausente §7.7). Los investigadores solo aparecen poniendo nombre al problema (Sleep researchers have even coined a term); el texto no les atribuye ninguna crítica precipitada.

Teoría: §6.2 Lo concreto del texto, lo abstracto de la opción · §6.1 Grados de paráfrasis

35 · C · Opinión y actitud

Pregunta: What is the writer's view of the claim that nobody is forced to treat the numbers as commandments?

Pasaje: párrafo 5. **Respuesta propia:** Es verdad, pero tramposo: los aparatos están diseñados para que no puedas ignorarlos.

A It is false, because the devices cannot be switched off.
Falla (alcance §7.3). El autor dice That is true, y en el último párrafo él mismo ha desactivado los avisos (I have switched off the reminders).

B It is fair, since the reminders are easy to ignore.
Falla (lógica §7.5). Invierte el argumento: los aparatos están diseñados to be hard to ignore.

C It is accurate but misleading.
Correcta. El autor concede y gira en dos frases: That is true, but it is also somewhat disingenuous. Disingenuous es «poco sincero»: la afirmación es cierta, pero calla que los aparatos están hechos to be hard to ignore. La comparación con el casino refuerza la idea.

D It holds for occasional users but not for enthusiasts.
Falla (ausente §7.7). El texto no distingue tipos de usuario; la comparación con el casino (a casino does not oblige anyone to stay until dawn) vale para todos.

Teoría: §4.3 Ironía, understatement y concesión · §4.1 La voz del autor frente a las voces citadas

36 · D · Global

Pregunta: Which best describes the writer's overall attitude to self-tracking devices?

Pasaje: el texto completo. **Respuesta propia:** Los sigue usando, pero con reservas y con sus propias condiciones.

A wholehearted rejection
Falla (alcance §7.3). Lo contradice el último párrafo: I have not thrown the watch away.

B reluctant admiration
Falla (eco léxico §7.1, pasaje vecino §7.8). La única admiración del texto es irónica: los aparatos están diseñados with considerable skill, pero para ser difíciles de ignorar, algo que el autor critica.

C amused indifference
Falla (medio cierto §7.6). El humor existe (la cocina, el casino), pero indifferent choca con What troubles me most: el asunto le importa.

D qualified acceptance
Correcta. Concede su utilidad (There is something to this), critica que conviertan las cifras en objetivos y termina en un término medio: conserva el reloj, pero le pone límites (worth consulting, occasionally useful). Él mismo lo llama a modest compromise.

Teoría: §5.4 Preguntas globales · §4.4 Léxico de actitud en las opciones